

THE REVIVAL
Kamal Nath at a Congress rally in Bhind, Feb. 23

Former minister P.C. Sharma has been given charge of countering the BJP's 'disinformation campaign' against the party. Congress workers will go through a training programme, Jan Jagran Abhiyan, and a *ghar chalo, ghar ghar chalo* campaign will have them going house-to-house to apprise the people of party programmes while clarifying its stand on local and national issues. "The idea is to equip party workers with facts to counter the BJP's bogus claims," says state Congress spokesperson Bhupendra Gupta. Meanwhile, the party membership drive continues. The state unit strength is now around 1.9 million (compared to the BJP's 10 million claim), but Rajiv Singh is confident they will have "5 million members on the basis of membership receipts" by the time the AICC president election rolls out in mid-2022.

As for frontal organisations, the NSUI (National Students' Union of India) and Youth Congress are doing "satisfactory work". The Youth Congress, in fact, is running an '*ek booth, paanch youth*' programme, or five youth per booth. Party bosses, however, are unhappy with the Mahila Congress and Seva Dal. The old state Mahila Congress executive was scrapped, and Vibha Patel has been made the new president.

However, even with the overhaul and the new initiatives, there are certain legacy issues in the Congress Nath will find hard to overcome. Most importantly, unlike the BJP and its Hindutva-motivated cadre, ideological attachment to the Congress cause is very low. Attracting young, dedicated workers to the party has been difficult. In many booths, Congress membership has eroded to the extent of being absent. Even now, sitting MLAs or those who are ticket contenders are asked to appoint *mandalam* heads, so the primary allegiance is to the leader, not the party. Already, the appointment of *mandalam* in-charges has hit a rough patch in 30 per cent of the assembly seats.

The state leadership's soft-pedalling on the Hindutva front, be it pandering to cow politics or not taking a hard stand when Muslims and other minorities are attacked, is doing it no favour. In fact, Nath has left it to long-time friend and ally, ex-CM Digvijaya Singh, to ensure that the Congress's core issues, like concern for Dalits and minorities, are not ignored. The BJP has been attempting to drive a wedge between Nath and Digvijaya, claiming that all is not well between them. But party insiders say the two are on the same page on most issues.

Meanwhile, Nath is on overdrive at public meetings. Last week, he was in Rewa and Bhind, both areas where the Congress has seen setbacks. The idea is to enthuse workers and attempt to unite various Congress leaders by sharing the dais at such meetings. Nath has also been trying to draw youngsters in by highlighting the lack of work opportunities in MP. And he loses no opportunity to diss Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan. "I challenge Chouhan to present an account of the BJP's 17 years in power and I will present mine of 15 months," he said in Bhind. Chouhan is unlikely to take the bait, and it will be up to Nath to up the ante in the coming months. If he can keep up the pressure, the Congress veteran may yet get a chance to reclaim MP for the party. ■

CONGRESS PUSH FOR 2023

- Strengthen the party organisation at the grassroots level
- Training programmes for party workers to counter the BJP's 'disinformation campaign'
- Engage local leaders and workers at public meetings to keep up morale, create a buzz on social media and among the youth by raising their issues
- Work on unity among Congress leaders cutting across caste and regional lines